

Experts warn of AI’s toll on brain

Chatbots may support dangerous behavior among some frequent users of tool, they say.

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

Generative artificial intelligence has quickly permeated much of what we do online, proving helpful for many. But for a small minority of the hundreds of millions of people who use it daily, AI may be too supportive, mental health experts say, and can sometimes even exacerbate delusional and dangerous behavior.

Instances of emotional dependence and fantastical beliefs due to prolonged interactions with chatbots seemed to spread this year. Some have dubbed the phenomenon “AI psychosis.”

“What’s probably a more accurate term would be AI delusional thinking,” said Vaile Wright, senior director of healthcare innovation at the American Psychological Assn. “What we’re seeing with this phenomenon is that people with either con- [See AI, A11]

L.A. car wash tries to survive ICE raids

By KATE LINTHICUM

The car wash hadn’t yet opened for the day, but its owner was already on edge.

He scanned the street for law enforcement vehicles and hit refresh on a crowd-sourced map that showed recent immigration sweeps.

“They were busy in our area yesterday,” he warned his employees. “Be careful.”

But except for staying home, there were few precautions that the workers, mostly men from Mexico, could take.

The business is located along one of L.A.’s busiest thoroughfares. Workers are exposed to the street as they scrub, wax and buff the parade of vehicles that streams in between 7 a.m. and 4 p.m., seven days a week.

Immigration agents descended on the business multiple times this summer [See Car wash, A10]

An industry is upended by raids

Car washes were already struggling; then came ICE, Gustavo Arellano writes. CALIFORNIA, B1



Angelica, seen at 15, picks tomatillos in the Santa Maria Valley. She started working in the fields when she was 11 years old. She says she gets paid \$3 for each five-gallon bucket of tomatillos she fills. She also described toiling in fields where employers failed to provide shade and drinking water.

CHILDREN TOILING IN TOXIC FIELDS

State officials are failing to protect the health and safety of thousands of young farmworkers, an investigation has found

Story by Robert J. Lopez | Photographs by Barbara Davidson

REPORTING FROM MONTEREY COUNTY, CALIF.

The summer sun burned through the clouds in the Salinas Valley, where a bounty of berries and leafy green vegetables grows across this rich farmland renowned as the “Salad Bowl of the World.” Jose, a quiet 14-year-old, was squatting and bending over for hours with other workers in a sprawling strawberry field.

The pickers, many of them also minors, snapped berries from plants and placed them in plastic cartons, eight of them in a cardboard box. They moved quickly along the long rows that lined the field.

Jose was exhausted but working as fast as he could; he was being paid \$2.40 for each box he filled. As he ran with a full box, he fell on the uneven ground and twisted his ankle. It hurt for days, he later recalled, but he didn’t say anything to his boss for fear of losing his

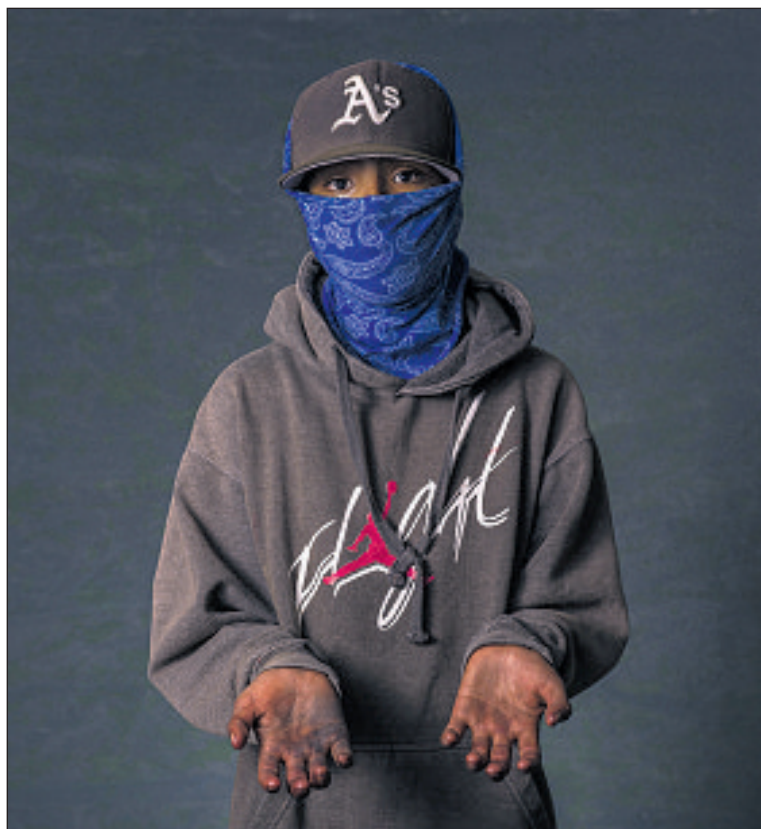
job.

“You just gotta suck it up, and you gotta work through it,” he said on a recent Sunday, his only day off that week. He has labored in the fields every summer and on weekends during the school year since he was 11 years old to help his mother, who also picks berries. His siblings, uncles and cousins — four of them minors — work in local strawberry fields.

Jose said that some days he didn’t fill many boxes and earned less than minimum wage for the hours he worked, which would be a violation of state child labor laws. He described toiling under the hot sun in fields where employers failed to provide shade for workers, as required by state law. He and his sister said they harvested strawberries in a [See Fields, A12]

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Derick, seen at 14, picks strawberries in the Salinas Valley. He started working in the fields when he was 13 years old to help his parents. He says the work is hard on his back, shoulders and legs.



An unexpected magnet for Californians lies a state away



LUIS SINCO Los Angeles Times

PACKED BOATS bob in Lake Havasu, Ariz. Recreationists descend in droves to the area in the summer.

By TERRY CASTLEMAN

In 1968, inventor Robert McCulloch purchased the decommissioned London Bridge for \$2.4 million and began to move it to newly founded Lake Havasu City, Ariz.

The bridge’s 10,276 granite blocks were shipped by sea to Long Beach, then trucked to Arizona.

Back then, moving the London Bridge to the desert elicited chuckles and curiosity in California. But in recent years, increasing numbers of Californians are taking that same trek from the

coast to start new lives in Lake Havasu.

The town famed for its spring break recreation might not be the first place that comes to mind when Californians think about relocating.

After all, in raw numbers, the biggest destination for Californians in the last few years has been Texas. When it comes to migration to Arizona, Maricopa County — home to Phoenix — saw the largest influx of Californians by sheer numbers, at 36,000 in 2023, U.S. Census data show.

But Lake Havasu City is impressive in two key

metrics:

Far more Californians move to the town per capita compared with the Phoenix area.

In 2023, which was the last year that data were available, 5,358 Californians moved to Mojave County (home to Havasu) compared with only 2,651 Arizonans. That is the highest ratio in Arizona.

So the city offers a useful window into how Californians resettle when they cross the Golden State border.

Amber Whitehead lived the first 47 years of her life in [See Havasu, A11]

LAFD records don’t match account

Logs show no deep mop-up of Lachman smolder fire, as the department had said.

By ALENE TCHEKMEDYIAN AND PAUL PRINGLE

In the weeks since federal investigators announced that the devastating Palisades fire was caused by a re-ignition of a smaller blaze, top Los Angeles Fire Department officials have insisted that they did everything they could to put out the earlier fire.

But The Times has obtained records that call into question the agency’s statements about how thoroughly firefighters mopped up the Jan. 1 Lachman fire in the days before it reignited.

In an interview last month, then-Interim Fire Chief Ronnie Villanueva said that firefighters returned to the burn area on Jan. 3 — due to a report of smoke — and “cold-trailed” an additional time, meaning they used their hands to feel for heat and dug out hot spots.

“We went back over there again. We dug it all out again. We put ladders on it. We did everything that we could do — cold-trail again,” Villanueva told The Times on Oct. 8. “We did all of that.”

A dispatch log obtained by The Times, however, shows that firefighters arrived at the scene that day and quickly reported seeing no smoke. They canceled the dispatch for another engine that was on the way, clearing the call within 34 minutes. The log does not mention cold-trailing. It’s unclear if crews took any other actions during the call, because the LAFD has not answered questions about it.

The Times has made multiple requests for comment to LAFD spokesperson Capt. Erik Scott by email, text and in person, but the agency has refused to explain the discrepancy. Villanueva also did not respond to an emailed request for comment and an interview request.

The conflict between the LAFD’s statements and its own records is likely to intensify frustration and anger among Palisades fire victims [See LAFD, A10]

Marjorie Taylor Greene to resign

Former Trump loyalist, who has become a critic, says she’ll step down from Congress in January. NATION, A6

Crews fight ship fire off L.A. port

A shelter-in-place order is lifted for San Pedro and Wilmington as blaze diminishes. CALIFORNIA, B1

Dive into our holiday preview

Our picks of the best on TV, in theaters and music, and a bounty of “Nutcracker” shows. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather

Sunny.

L.A. Basin: 70/52. B8

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